First Congregational Church of St. Albans (FCC) is a welcoming community of spiritual seekers, believers, and doubters.

Please know that no *matter who you are or where you are on life's journey, you're welcome here.*

First Congregational Church Vision Statement

To create an open and loving community that encourages a joyous exploration with God.
To work together to care for and nurture the wider community.

First Congregational Church Mission Statement

Our mission as a community resource church is to provide a safe place for spiritual exploration and personal growth. To affirm the value of each person and to meet them where they are.
To connect to the community through personal service, giving, and pastoral care.

Please feel free to contact us:
Administrative Office: Monday: 2pm-4pm; Tuesday 8am-2pm; Wednesday 9am-Noon; Thursday 8am-2pm; Friday 10am-Noon.
Church Office Phone Number: 802-524-4555
Pastor Jessica's Office Hours: Tues. & Wed, 9am-12pm, and by appt.
Email: pastorjessica@firstcongregationalstalbans.org
For urgent, pastoral matters outside of regular office hours, call Pastor Jessica at 207-632-5544.

Our worship service is broadcast over the local public access channel 1079 on Sundays at 4 PM.

Scripture Reader: Mara Vijups

UNITED CHURCH OF CHRIST

First Congregational Church of St. Albans

An open and affirming community.



"We welcome you and serve all through faith."

Worship with us:

December 3, 2023

10 am

Rev. Jessica Moore, Pastor
Stephan Conrady, Organist
Monica Newton, Office Manager

27 Church Street, St. Albans, VT 05478
802-524-4555
info@firstcongregationalstalbans.org
www.firstcongregationalstalbans.org

We Gather as God's People

Centering Words:
"Everything visible, without exception, is the outpouring of God. What else could it really be?" Richard Rohr, *The Universal Christ*

❖ BEGINNING OF SERVICE ❖

THE PREPARATION

The beginning of the prelude is a call to enter into the spirit of prayer and community.

Prelude ***Advent Music***

Welcome and Announcements

Sung Call To Worship Come and Fill Our Hearts (Taizé)

Come and fill our hearts with your hope,
You alone, O God, are holy.
Come and fill our hearts with your hope,
Al-le-lu--ia!

Morning Prayer (**Unison**)

Creating and sustaining God,
In your presence there is life.
Living Water springs up,
And deserts blossom where you pass.
Seeking the life that comes from you,
We have gathered before you.
Our hearts are ready, O God.
Delight us with your presence,
And prepare us for your service in the world.
Amen

Welcome to all visitors: We are delighted that you chose to worship with us today and are strengthened by your participation in our service!
If you are new to First Congregational Church of St. Albans, please sign the guest book in the narthex (main entrance of the church).
If you would like more information about our church and its programs or would like to receive our Morning Reflections, and weekly e-newsletter, "From the Manse," please fill out a Welcome Card and place it in the Offering tray (be sure to include your email address).

After the service please join us for fellowship, conversation, coffee, and refreshments.

*Please Stand If You Are Able

From Worship Design Studios: Reflecting Advent

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THE THANKSGIVING

Sharing Our Joys and Concerns

Choral Call to Prayer:

Hear Our Prayer, O Lord D. Welpton

Prayer of the People ~

Choral Response to Prayer

"*Thou wilt keep him in perfect peace, whose mind is stayed on Thee.*" Scottish Psalter, 1615

THE DEPARTURE

Voices of Longing

N. Holland, V. Walden, S. Odrechowski, T. Odrechowski, M. Newton, S. Christman

Postlude ***Advent Music***

❖ END OF SERVICE ❖

Announcements:

Music Notes: You may recognize this chorale tune stretched out over a roving organ part. This chorale also made a special appearance in the 60's as a tune from the Swingle Singers called "Sleepytime Bach", for which the lyrics are "doo-doobie-doo do-wah".

Next week we are pleased to welcome singers from Saint Michael's College to provide special music during Sunday worship.

Concert: Today at 3pm the Citizens Concert Band performs! The program will consist of Christmas music and carols with an audience singalong. It's FREE (donations welcome) - bring your friends and neighbors!

Lighting of the HOPE Advent Candle

Kent Gramm and Camelia Maianu

When the world is frightening
And we desire to escape from the ongoing suffering,
The Womb of Creation invites us to remember a hope within.
It is the hope within us that leads us to transform the conditions around us.
We cling to hope in a world full of despair.
We search for it;
We dare to discover hope in the small, yet magnificent moments of our days.
Let us light this candle of hope as we remember the God-with-us and the hope within us.

Hymn*

"O Come, O Come, Emmanuel" (1, 2, 3) NCH 116

Prayer of Confession

This has been a year of disquiet and suffering, O God.
We live in a world that worships money and brute force, sowing the seeds of fear and hatred.
At times we get caught up in this, and forget to share Your love with everyone.
Holy One, shine your face upon us!
Restore us to You and the eternal hope only You can bring.
Amen

Pause for Reflection

Words of Assurance

Passing of the Peace

THE MESSAGE

Anthem "Zion Hears The Watchmen's Voices" from Sleepers Awake (BWV 140) J.S. Bach

Scripture Reading

Luke 1:26-38

Morning Reflection: ***Meditations on Mary: Openness***

Hymn*

"Let Us Break Bread Together" NCH 330

THE COMMUNION

One: The invitation is simple: come and eat of the feast. Not a meal to nourish the body, but to feed the soul. We receive the bread and juice connected to the ages: to the saint of old who felt unworthy, to the seeker eager to know God, to the one who wonders what it's all about, to the one who eats with unburdened faith. Woven into this time are the hopes and tears of generations. There is great joy here. No one is turned away for God is the host! May the peace of the Lord be with you always.

All: And also with you.

One: Lift up your hearts.

All: We lift them up to the Lord.

One: Let us give thanks to the Lord our God.

All: It is right to give God thanks and praise.

Pause

All: Loving God, recalling Christ's gracious life and death, and proclaiming the resurrection, we offer this bread and cup. Send your Holy Spirit upon us and upon these gifts, that they may be for us the body and blood of our Lord Jesus Christ, and being built up by this precious sacrament of grace, we may receive the gift of eternal life in the blessed and heavenly realm.

One: We ask this in the name of Jesus Christ, praying the prayer taught to the disciples:

All: Our Father, who art in heaven, hallowed be thy name. Thy kingdom come, thy will be done, on earth as it is in heaven. Give us this day our daily bread, and forgive us our trespasses as we forgive those who trespass against us. And lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from evil, for thine is the kingdom and the power and the glory, forever. Amen.

One: Gathered with his friends, Jesus took bread, broke it and said, "This is my body, broken for you. Take and eat."
And Jesus took the juice and said, "This is my blood, spilled out for you. Do this in remembrance of me."

Distribution of the Bread and Cup: please hold your cup until we serve all, so that all may drink together.

One: Let us pray.

All: Gracious God, we thank you for refreshing us at your table. May we who share Christ's bread live his risen life. May we who drink Christ's cup bring abundant life to others. May the Holy Spirit who lights the world also enlighten our lives. Strengthen in us the hope you set before us, so that we and all your children shall be free, and so that the whole earth may live to praise your name. Amen.